



'I feel proud that I was the first one to overcome the hurdles that women athletes face'

Pranay Rajiv

pranay.rajiv@thehindu.co.in

She is a two-time World Champion and has won countless other medals in the national and international competitions. But Karnam Malleswari will be forever remembered for the bronze she won in the 69 kg weightlifting at the Sydney Olympics in 2000, which made her the first Indian woman to medal at the biggest sporting event in the world.

Following her path, six more Indian women have brought home an Olympic medal. But as the saying goes, the first step is often the most significant one.

"It is a great feeling [to be the first Indian woman to win an Olympic medal]. I feel proud that I was the first one to overcome the hurdles that women athletes face," said Malleswari, after she was awarded the Lifetime Achievement Award at the Sportstar Aces Awards 2024 held at the Taj Mahal Palace in Mumbai.

"I started my weightlifting journey when I was 12. There was a weightlifting gym near my home in Amadalavalasa, Andhra Pradesh, where girls used to train. Inspired by them, I also tried out the sport. I never imagined I would reach where I am today. It all started just as fun. But with time, as my performance improved, my interest grew and so did my focus," reminisced Malleswari.

Malleswari credited her husband

Rajesh Tyagi and her mother as the "two pillars" who helped her climb the pedestals of weightlifting.

"Before my marriage, it was my mother who supported me. And after marriage, my husband took over that role. He helped me through all the obstacles I faced in my career.

"What is truly great about his support is that he was a national-level weightlifter. But he understood that I had more potential and talent. So, he compromised his career and told me that he would take care of everything so that I can go onto the next level and achieve my dreams," said Malleswari.

One of the six Indian women to follow Malleswari's footsteps to Olympic glory was Mirabai Chanu, who, in 2021, did one better than her predecessor by winning silver in the 49 kg weightlifting at the Tokyo Games.

Mirabai added a gold at the 2022

Commonwealth Games but has since been held back by a spate of injuries. Malleswari, though, has faith that the Manipuri weightlifter will bounce back in time for the Paris Games.

"Back injury is very common in weightlifting. At the 2004 Athens Olympics, I too suffered a similar injury, which eventually ended my career. The good thing [for Mirabai] is that, unlike in our time, there are a lot of facilities available."

"The Sports Ministry is supporting her, and she is getting good treatment and training from top-class facilities abroad. I have total belief that she will recover in time for the Paris Olympics and bring home another medal," added Malleswari.

Mirabai's performance, though, has papered over a rather lacklustre spell for Indian weightlifting, with only three athletes qualifying for the Hangzhou Asian Games in the sport. Malleswari is pinning her hopes on the next generation to change the script.



'I can feel a growing sense of interest in the sport. All the talent in my academy have come from the grassroots level and a lot of them have already won medals at the national and international level'